

TECH LEADERS DEALING WITH RECESSION

SATYA NADELLA

"By 2008, storm clouds were gathering over Microsoft. PC shipments, the financial lifeblood of Microsoft, had leveled off. Meanwhile, sales of Apple and Google smartphones and tablets were on the rise, producing growing revenues from search and online advertising that Microsoft hadn't matched," Nadella observes in his book *Hit Refresh: The Quest to Rediscover Microsoft's Soul and Imagine a Better Future for Everyone*. Believe it or not, 2008 was also the year of Bill Gates' departure from Microsoft, but it was also the period of Satya Nadella's rise and the Redmond-based software giants renewed focus towards cloud computing, a journey that only accelerated after Satya Nadella became CEO of Microsoft in 2014. Microsoft today has a market capitalization of \$2 trillion, largely thanks to the company's pivot post the 2008 Global Recession.

ELON MUSK

The richest man in the world has been busy with a lot of things on his mind – SpaceX rocket launches, Tesla cars and trying to purchase Twitter. All that hasn't stopped the real-world Tony Stark from verbalizing his thoughts on the social media platform he wants to purchase, and some of those thoughts have been his observations of the impending recession. "I think we probably are in a recession and that recession will get worse," the billionaire said on May 16 during a virtual appearance at the recent All-In Conference held in Miami, according to reports. Beyond just a warning, Elon Musk also showed a lot of optimism towards the recession. "But you know, these things pass and then there will be boom times again." The Tesla CEO further added that the recession will "probably" last 12 to 18 months.

MARK ZUCKERBERG

The founder and CEO of Facebook (now known as Meta), the world's most used social platform, isn't too worried about the impending recession, according to an interview with CNBC in May 2022. Despite the departure of Facebook's COO Sheryl Sandberg (who potentially transformed the fledgling social media service into an unmatched advertising powerhouse), Mark Zuckerberg is fairly confident that Meta will weather any impending recession without a huge impact to their business. "Well, I mean, over the course of running this company, we have gone through recessions and we're, you know, we'll navigate that however we need to but look, I mean, the way that I think about this is there are two major underlying trends that are driving our business," Zuckerberg was quoted as saying, highlighting his company's investments in Metaverse and cutting-edge AI technologies for fine tuning content and user matching better than ever before. Like

many of his peers in big-tech companies, Zuckerberg is banking on innovative tech solutions to ride the recession.

SUNDAR PICHAI

Even Google and Alphabet CEO Sundar Pichai agrees that a recession is inevitable this year, and that it "will affect the tech sector," Pichai was quoted as saying in an interview on the sidelines of Google I/O Developer Conference in May 2022. Beyond the Covid-19 pandemic, Pichai also pointed to the Russian invasion of Ukraine and supply chain disruptions around the world as concerns. "Economies tend to have cycles, and the tech industry tends to have more volatile cycles," Pichai said, according to a Nikkei report. Despite all the doom and gloom, Pichai believes technology creates "real value" for the economy, reflecting on plans to hire 12,000 people just in the U.S. in 2022, up about 20% from the previous year to execute critical "long term" plans of the company's strategic roadmap.

JEFF BEZOS

While he isn't the CEO of Amazon anymore, Jeff Bezos is still the company's executive chairman – which means he has significant capacity to influence Amazon's journey through the impending recession. Talking about recessions, Jeff Bezos has rallied through several recessions throughout his 27-year journey with Amazon, coming out stronger than ever through each one over three decades. In an interview with The Wall Street Journal in 2008, Bezos said, "I think frugality drives innovation, just like other constraints do. One of the only ways to get out of a tight box is to invent your way out." This is as good an advice as any you could receive from a man who has seen and done everything to re-invent the company's fortunes from an e-commerce marketplace to hosting most of the browsable Internet on its servers, and beyond.

WARREN BUFFETT

Not just known around the world as a masterful stock market investor (the Oracle Of Omaha), Warren Buffett has invested in and still holds the stocks of several successful technology companies in the world – from Apple to Amazon, to Mastercard and many others. Technology companies, in fact, make up a significant portion of his investment portfolio every single year. Needless to say, the 91-year-old billionaire has seen several recessions in his lifetime, and to weather each and every single one of them comes down to a simple fact, according to Buffett. Speaking at the 2022 Berkshire Hathaway annual shareholders meeting in May 2022, Buffett repeated his long-held advice that one of the strongest protections against inflation is sharpening your skills and working to be at the top of your field. "The best thing you can do is to be exceptionally good at something," the 91-year-old said.